

Practice Paper 47 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — “As though I were a librarian he had only just met”

1 mark for identifying that he was **unusually formal / polite / courteous**.

1 mark for explaining that this is **strange** given that he is her grandfather — the comparison suggests he was treating her with **gentle respect / dignity**, not as a child but as someone offering a professional service.

Q2. [2] — Evidence she had never done this kind of reading before

1 mark each for any two of:

- She was “nervous in a way I had not expected”.
- She mentions her past experience was only “essays in class and birthday cards at parties”.
- She states directly: “I had never read to a person who could not, by himself, read back”.
- She notes she was only “fifteen” — emphasising her inexperience.

Q3. [2] — “Rushed past me like a bus I had failed to flag down”

1 mark — She was reading **too quickly / without control** — the words moved past faster than she could catch them.

1 mark — The image of **failing to flag down a bus** suggests that she felt **helpless** — even though she was the one reading, she could not slow herself down or grasp what she was saying.

Q4. [2] — “The way one might offer a cup of tea”

1 mark — His correction was **gentle, unforced and ordinary** — he did not embarrass her or make her feel foolish.

1 mark — The comparison suggests **warmth and hospitality**: a cup of tea is something offered out of kindness, not obligation, and may be declined without offence — so too the correction.

Q5. [2] — His teaching had changed

(a) [1]: He no longer **corrected essays or marked homework**; instead, he taught through **patient listening**, by **waiting** for her, and by **gently murmuring** corrections — that is, through **example** rather than instruction.

(b) [1]: It suggests he is a **patient, humble and adaptable** man — even when blind and unable to teach in his old way, he continues to share his knowledge through **quiet generosity**.

Q6. [3] — Engagement with the stories (language question)

1 mark for identifying that the grandfather is **physically still but emotionally / mentally alive** to the stories; **1 mark each** for **two** clearly quoted and explained details (max 2).

Accept any two of:

- “His head tilted at the funny parts” — small involuntary movement shows he is **responding** to humour.
- “His mouth tightened, very slightly, at the sad ones” — small physical reaction reveals genuine **emotional engagement**.
- He “murmured the name of a writer I had never heard of” — shows his **mind is still working, recalling** literature.
- He “asked me, afterwards, to look up a particular phrase” — he is still **curious** and **intellectually active**.

Each detail must be **quoted** and **explained**; mere lifting without explanation = ½ mark.

Q7. [2] — “The room felt as though it would tip into silence”

1 mark — The atmosphere was **fragile / delicate / precious** — as if the moment could collapse easily.

1 mark — The verb **tip** suggests **imbalance**: the room is on the edge of something profound, and only her continued voice keeps the **quiet memory** alive — silence would feel like a loss.

Q8. [1] — Why his opening his eyes is significant

1 mark — Throughout the readings he keeps his eyes **closed** (he has given up on the visible world); opening them shows that the story has reached him **unusually deeply** — it has stirred a **long-buried memory** and pulled him momentarily **out of his usual stillness**.

Q9. [1] — “Spaces between” the words

1 mark — She means the **pauses, silences and breathing** in a text — the rhythm of reading, the moments when one **waits** rather than speaks. He was teaching her to value what is **not said**, not only what is said.

Q10. [2] — “The story would still be there tomorrow”

1 mark — His tiredness is suggested **gently**, without complaint — he does not want her to feel rejected.

1 mark — The remark also reflects his **patience and his sense of slowness**: he has no need to

rush a story to its end, because the story will **wait** for them. (Also accept: a quiet hint that his time is short, yet he chooses to speak of the story's continuation rather than his own ending.)

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **tender, reflective, grateful, reverent, quietly affectionate**. (Reject: **sad, bitter** — these miss the gratitude.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — Significant and widespread trend

1 mark each for any two of:

- The average length has fallen from “four minutes and twenty seconds” to “under three minutes and ten seconds” — a fall of “more than a quarter”.
- The change has occurred “within a single generation” — i.e. very rapidly.
- It is **not confined** to one genre: “pop, hip-hop, country, and K-pop alike”.
- It is **not confined** to one country.

Q13. [2] — Why short songs are more profitable

1 mark — A song pays the same royalty regardless of length, provided the listener has heard **at least thirty seconds** — so a short song earns a label the same per play as a long one.

1 mark — A short song is **more likely to be replayed** by the same listener, generating **more plays and more royalties** than a longer song would in the same period.

Q14. [1] — “Brutally”

1 mark — The word suggests the writer finds the industry’s logic **harsh, cold and indifferent to art** — profit is calculated without sentiment or regard for the song itself.

Q15. [2] — Changes to the opening of a song

1 mark each for any two of:

- The first fifteen seconds are now designed as a “hook-on-arrival” — an immediate grab for attention.
- A “recognisable melody” or “memorable phrase” must appear at once.
- A “beat that arrives almost before the singer does” — the rhythm leads, not the voice.
- The **slow build, gentle introduction, patient unfolding** of a chorus from a verse has become rare.

Q16. [2] — “The cold language of the platform”

1 mark — **Cold** emphasises that the streaming service speaks in **unemotional, commercial, data-driven** terms — songs are measured by metrics, not by beauty.

1 mark — **Language of the platform** personifies the streaming service as **speaking its own jargon** (e.g. “convert” — a marketing word, not a musical one) — emphasising how the **vocabulary of business** has invaded the world of song.

Q17. [2] — “Used so often that it has worn smooth”

1 mark — The writer is **wary** of the phrase — it has become a **cliché**, used so much that it has lost its sharpness.

1 mark — Yet he does not dismiss it; he immediately adds that “the underlying claim is real enough” — showing his attitude is **critical but fair**: he distrusts the **fashionable label** while accepting the **substance** behind it.

Q18. [1] — Why include the UCL study

1 mark — To provide **concrete, quantitative evidence** for what might otherwise sound like an opinion — the very specific figure (“under forty seconds”) **grounds the argument in measurable fact** and adds **credibility**.

Q19. [2] — “Craft as much as commerce”

1 mark — **Craft** refers to the **art** of songwriting — what musicians choose to put into a song (long instrumental sections, key changes, second choruses with new lyrics).

1 mark — O’Connell is arguing that songs have shortened not only because of **money** (commerce), but because **musical tastes and skills have changed** — modern listeners simply **do not miss** those older devices, so songwriters no longer include them.

Q20. [2] — Defenders’ arguments

1 mark each for any two of:

- Brevity is itself a **discipline** — it forces songwriters to be efficient.
- A short song has **no wasted bar** — every moment must justify itself.
- The result may be a **leaner and more honest** kind of pop.
- A short song “must say what it has to say and then have the dignity to stop” — concision is presented as a virtue.

Q21. [2] — “No committee voted, in 2008, to halve the length of the love song”

1 mark — The sentence is **witty and ironic** — by imagining a literal committee, the writer makes vivid the idea that the change was **not the result of any conscious decision**.

1 mark — It is **effective** because it emphasises how the shift has been **gradual, anonymous and economic** — driven by infrastructure, not by artistic intent — which is the writer’s main argument in the paragraph.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points (½ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why pop songs have grown shorter (Paragraphs 2–5):

1. Streaming services pay a **royalty after only thirty seconds**, so a short song earns as much per play as a long one.
2. Short songs are **replayed more often**, generating **more plays / income** per listener.
3. The **opening must hook** the listener immediately, leaving no room for slow builds.
4. Listeners — especially young ones — have **shorter attention spans**, trained by fast video and scrolling feeds.
5. **Musical taste has changed**: long instrumentals, key changes and second choruses are no longer missed.
6. The average length is also pulled down by a **flood of very short tracks** that would once have been considered demos.

What is lost or gained (Paragraph 6):

7. **Lost**: Room for **bridges, key changes, and surprising verses** — the lyrical and emotional development of a song is reduced.

8. **Gained:** The discipline of **brevity** — songs become **leaner and more honest**, with no wasted bar.

Sample full-marks summary (77 words):

Pop songs have grown shorter because streaming services pay a royalty once a track is played for thirty seconds, so brief, easily replayed tracks earn labels more per listener. Openings must hook immediately, audiences accustomed to fast video have shorter attention spans, and modern tastes no longer miss long instrumentals or key changes. Very brief tracks now flood the charts. Songs lose room for emotional development, yet gain a tighter discipline that arguably produces leaner, more honest pop.

Length count: 77 words from “Pop” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —